

Week 4 — Duality Theory and Conic Programming

AD7031 Optimization Under Uncertainty • Instructor: Prof. H. Park • Sep 19, 2026

1. Duality theory

in this course, we focus on **convex** functions.

Primal Problem

$$\begin{aligned} \inf \quad & f_0(x) \\ \text{s.t.} \quad & x \in \mathbb{R}^N \\ & f_i(x) \leq 0 \quad \forall i \in [I] \end{aligned} \tag{P}$$

Dual Problem

$$\begin{aligned} \sup_{\theta} \quad & \inf_{x \in \mathbb{R}^N} f_0(x) + \sum_{i \in [I]} \theta_i f_i(x) \\ \text{s.t.} \quad & \theta \in \mathbb{R}^I \\ & \theta \geq 0 \end{aligned} \tag{D}$$

$\begin{aligned} \inf \quad & f_0(x) \\ \text{s.t.} \quad & x \in \mathbb{R}^N \\ & f_i(x) \leq 0 \quad \forall i \in [I] \end{aligned}$
$= \inf_{x \in \mathbb{R}^N} f_0(x) + \underbrace{\sup_{\theta \in \mathbb{R}_+^I} \sum_{i \in [I]} \theta_i f_i(x)}_{\leq 0}$

$$\begin{aligned} \text{if } f_i(x) \leq 0 \quad \forall i, \quad & \text{then } = 0 \\ \text{if } \exists i : f_i(x) > 0, \quad & \text{then } = +\infty \end{aligned}$$

$$\geq \sup_{\theta \in \mathbb{R}_+^I} \inf_{x \in \mathbb{R}^N} f_0(x) + \sum_{i \in [I]} \theta_i f_i(x)$$

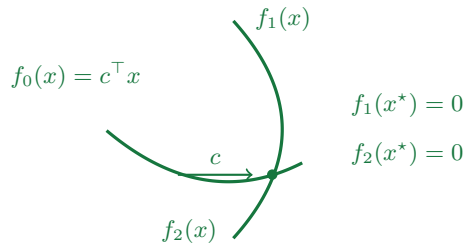
Properties:

— **weak duality** $\inf(P) \geq \sup(D)$ always holds.

— **strong duality:** $\inf(P) = \sup(D)$ holds

when the problem (P) is convex and the Slater's condition holds

$$\exists x \in \mathbb{R}^N, \text{ s.t. } f_i(x) < 0 \quad \forall i \in [I]$$



In this course, we assume that strong duality holds for convex problem!!

2. Example: linear program

Primal LP:

$$\begin{aligned} \inf \quad & c^\top x \\ \text{s.t.} \quad & x \in \mathbb{R}^N \\ & Ax \leq b \end{aligned} \quad \begin{aligned} f_0(x) &= c^\top x \\ f_i(x) &= a_i^\top x - b_i \quad \forall i \in [I] \end{aligned}$$

$$\begin{aligned} f_i(x) &\leq 0 \\ \iff a_i^\top x - b_i &\leq 0 \\ \iff a_i^\top x &\leq b_i \end{aligned}$$

Dual LP:

$$\begin{aligned} & \sup_{\theta \in \mathbb{R}_+^I} \inf_{x \in \mathbb{R}^N} c^\top x + \sum_{i \in [I]} \theta_i (a_i^\top x - b_i) \\ &= \sup_{\theta \in \mathbb{R}_+^I} \inf_{x \in \mathbb{R}^N} c^\top x + \sum_{i \in [I]} \theta_i a_i^\top x - \sum_{i \in [I]} \theta_i b_i \\ &= \sup_{\theta \in \mathbb{R}_+^I} - \sum_{i \in [I]} \theta_i b_i + \underbrace{\inf_{x \in \mathbb{R}^N} \left(c + \sum_{i \in [I]} \theta_i a_i \right)^\top x}_{= \begin{cases} 0 & \text{if } c + \sum_{i \in [I]} \theta_i a_i = 0 \\ -\infty & \text{if otherwise.} \end{cases}} \\ &= \sup_{\theta \in \mathbb{R}_+^I} -b^\top \theta \\ & \text{s.t.} \quad A^\top \theta = -c \end{aligned}$$

LP strong duality : if there exists $x \in \mathbb{R}^N : Ax \leq b$

$$\text{or } \theta \in \mathbb{R}^I : A^\top \theta = -c, \theta \geq 0$$

then strong duality holds

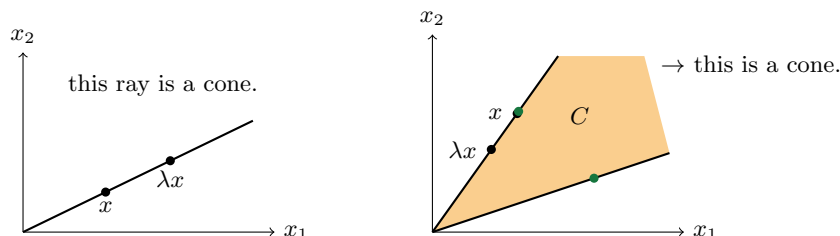
3. Conic programming

a conic program is a convex optimization problem.

— a **linear** objective function.

— a feasible set defines through the intersection of halfspaces $Ax \leq b$ or a proper cone.

Def (cone) a set C is a cone if $\forall x \in C$, we have $\lambda x \in C \quad \forall \lambda \geq 0$



Def (proper cone) $\mathbb{R}^N$ is a cone but not pointed.

C is a proper cone if it's **convex, closed, pointed**

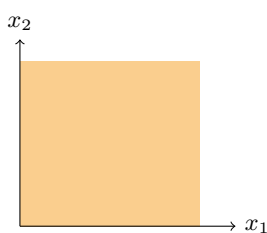
if $x, -x \in C$ then $x = 0$.

Generic conic program:

$$\begin{aligned} \inf \quad & c^\top x \\ \text{s.t.} \quad & x \in \mathbb{R}^N \quad \iff \quad b - Ax \in C \\ & Ax \preceq_C b \end{aligned}$$

Example:

1) **Linear program:** $C = \mathbb{R}_+^K$



$$\begin{aligned} b - Ax &\in \mathbb{R}_+^K \\ \iff b - Ax &\geq 0 \iff Ax \leq b \end{aligned}$$

2) **Semidefinite program:** $C = \mathbb{S}_+^K$

$\mathbb{S}^K$: set of symmetric matrices in $\mathbb{R}^{K \times K}$ ($A^\top = A$)

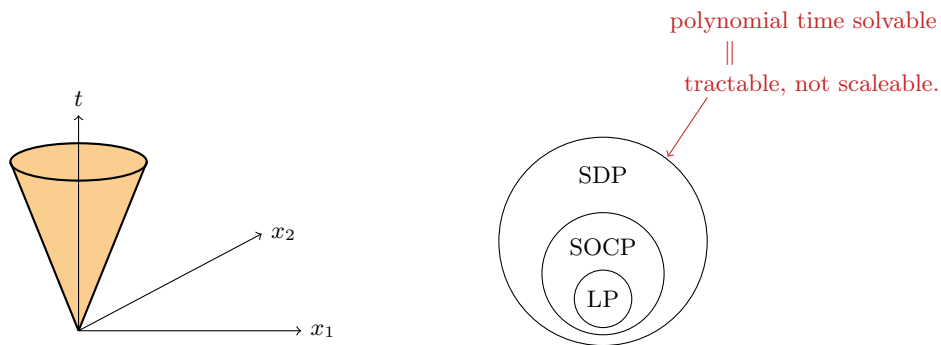
$\mathbb{S}_+^K$: set of positive semidefinite (symmetric) matrices in $\mathbb{R}^{K \times K}$

$A \in \mathbb{S}_+^K$ if $z^\top A z \geq 0 \quad \forall z \in \mathbb{R}^K$

Generic semidefinite program:

$$\begin{aligned} \inf \quad & c^\top x \\ \text{s.t.} \quad & x \in \mathbb{R}^N \quad \rightarrow \text{usually ignored} \\ & A_1 x_1 + A_2 x_2 + \dots + A_N x_N \preceq_{\mathbb{S}_+^K} B \end{aligned}$$

3) **Second-order cone:** $C = \{(x, t) \in \mathbb{R}^N \times \mathbb{R} : \|x\|_2 \leq t\}$ “ice-cream” cone



4. Conic programming duality

Def (*dual cone*)

$$C^* = \{y \in \mathbb{R}^K : \langle y, x \rangle \geq 0 \quad \forall x \in C\}$$

Self dual cones ($C = C^*$)

— $C = \mathbb{R}_+^K$

— $C = \mathbb{S}_+^K$

— $C = \text{second-order cone}$

Primal conic program:

$$\begin{aligned} \inf \quad & c^\top x \\ \text{s.t.} \quad & x \in \mathbb{R}^N \\ & Ax \preceq_c b \end{aligned}$$

Dual conic program:

$$\begin{aligned} \sup \quad & -\theta^\top b \\ \text{s.t.} \quad & \theta \in C^* \\ & A^\top \theta = -c \end{aligned}$$